

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 1541

By Mitchell

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of songwriting legend Don Schlitz.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Don Schlitz, a celebrated songwriter who penned some of country music's most enduring songs; and

WHEREAS, Don Schlitz is best known for chart-topping hits that include Kenny Rogers's "The Gambler," Randy Travis's "On the Other Hand" and "Forever and Ever, Amen," Mary Chapin Carpenter's "He Thinks He'll Keep Her," and Keith Whitley's "When You Say Nothing At All"; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Schlitz's first-ever recorded song was Kenny Rogers's "The Gambler," setting an incredible standard that he would meet for the rest of his career; and

WHEREAS, at the tender age of twenty-three, Don Schlitz celebrated a massive crossover hit with "The Gambler," which won the Grammy for Best Country Song in 1978 and was named the Country Music Association's Song of the Year in 1979; and

WHEREAS, during his long and distinguished career, Mr. Schlitz achieved twenty-five No. 1 tracks and fifty Top Ten singles and shaped the careers of Kenny Rogers, Randy Travis, The Judds, Nitty Gritty Dirt Band, Tanya Tucker, Mary Chapin Carpenter, Keith Whitley, Alison Krauss, and many more; and

WHEREAS, Don Schlitz was lionized as the ASCAP Country Songwriter of the Year from 1988 to 1991, and he won three Country Music Association Song of the Year Awards, two Academy of Country Music Song of the Year awards, and two Grammys across his five decades in music; and

WHEREAS, he had been inducted into the Nashville Songwriter Hall of Fame, Songwriters Hall of Fame, and Country Music Hall of Fame, where he was only the sixth songwriter so honored at the time; and

WHEREAS, when Kenny Rogers inducted Mr. Schlitz into the Songwriters Hall of Fame, he said, "Don doesn't just write songs, he writes careers"; and

WHEREAS, in 2022, Don Schlitz became the first non-artist songwriter inducted into the Grand Ole Opry in the show's 100-year history, an honor that speaks volumes about the high regard in which he was held by the country music industry; and

WHEREAS, the Saturday night performance of the Grand Ole Opry on April 18, 2026, was dedicated in Mr. Schlitz's honor; and

WHEREAS, a man of great empathy, Mr. Schlitz donated his time and talents to charity and was a stalwart supporter of Room In The Inn for nearly twenty years; and

WHEREAS, he often sang on Room In The Inn's stage in support of Nashville's unhoused community, serenaded residents' on their birthday, and encouraged people in its recovery programs; he also performed at Nashville's homeless memorial; and

WHEREAS, born and raised in Durham, North Carolina, Don Schlitz briefly attended Duke University before moving to Nashville at the age of twenty; arriving in Music City with a mere eighty dollars to his name, he set out for Music Row, where his talent was quickly recognized and fostered by country music greats, including Bob McDill and Bobby Bare; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Schlitz was one of the first performers at the now-iconic Bluebird Café in Nashville; he and his friends, Thom Schuyler, J. Fred Knobloch, and Paul Overstreet, originated the Café's songwriter-in-the-round format in 1985; and

WHEREAS, on Tuesday nights, Mr. Schlitz held court at the venue with his "Don For A Dollar" show, charging a cover of only one dollar; and

WHEREAS, he is survived by his wife, Stacey; his daughter, Cory Dixon, and her husband, Matt Dixon; his son, Pete Schlitz, and his wife, Christian Webb Schlitz; his

grandchildren, Roman, Gia, Isla, and Lilah; his brother, Brad Schlitz; and his sister, Kathy Hinkley; and

WHEREAS, in addition to his great talent, Don Schlitz was a hard-working artist who carefully crafted his songs into masterpieces about the human experience, and he became an icon and inspiration for a new generation of songwriters; and

WHEREAS, we were richer for his presence, and the country music industry will mourn his loss, as will the citizens of Nashville and the State of Tennessee; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Don Schlitz, one of the greatest songwriters in country music history, reflecting fondly upon his peerless catalog of music and his indelible legacy as an artist and human being.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express our sympathy and offer our condolences to the family of Don Schlitz.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.